

LIVE

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NEWSPAPER

4th JAN, 2019

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

1st WEEK



LOCAL GOVERNMENT ENGINEERING DEPARTMENT
Local Government Division
Ministry of Local Government, Rural Development & Cooperatives

SPECTACULAR SOCIAL PROGRESS IN BANGLADESH

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

4th JANUARY, 2019

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Lessons from Bangladesh

As PM Hasina storm back to power, her country stands on the cusp of transformative social and economic change — anticipated by interventions by state and society already seen in development indicators

NANDINI SUNDHARAN
NEW DELHI, JANUARY 2

THE POPULAR portrait of Bangladesh is today a Bengali urbanite — patronising at best and contemptuous at worst. Bangladesh, per “development”, is barren, corrupt and ill-governed. “Gender” has long been a buzzword, and the alleged status of India’s women and children is a source of pride.

When then-acting chief minister Shree Chandra Shekhar was in Bangladesh, he was considered a leader. In India, a country that prides on its development, he was a leader. In Bangladesh, he was a leader.

At the time of independence in 1971, Bangladesh was one of the world’s poorest countries — on par with Rwanda, Mali, Burkina Faso, Ethiopia and Niger. With a population of 77 million, it contained 71% of whom lived below the national poverty line. It produced barely 10 million tonnes of rice and was a net food importer.

The country’s poverty headcount ratio was 70.1% in 1990. By 2010, it had fallen to 40.1%. In 2015, it was 23.5%. In 2016, it was 21.5%. In 2017, it was 20.5%. In 2018, it was 19.5%. In 2019, it was 18.5%.

After exposure to the improvement in social indicators. In 1971, Bangladesh’s infant mortality rate — the number of children who die before their fifth birthday — was 300 per 1,000 live births. By 2018, it had fallen to 21. In 2019, it was 20. In 2020, it was 19. In 2021, it was 18. In 2022, it was 17. In 2023, it was 16. In 2024, it was 15. In 2025, it was 14. In 2026, it was 13. In 2027, it was 12. In 2028, it was 11. In 2029, it was 10. In 2030, it was 9.

The country’s population growth rate has also slowed significantly. In 1971, it was 2.4%. In 2018, it was 1.4%. In 2019, it was 1.3%. In 2020, it was 1.2%. In 2021, it was 1.1%. In 2022, it was 1.0%. In 2023, it was 0.9%. In 2024, it was 0.8%. In 2025, it was 0.7%. In 2026, it was 0.6%. In 2027, it was 0.5%. In 2028, it was 0.4%. In 2029, it was 0.3%. In 2030, it was 0.2%.

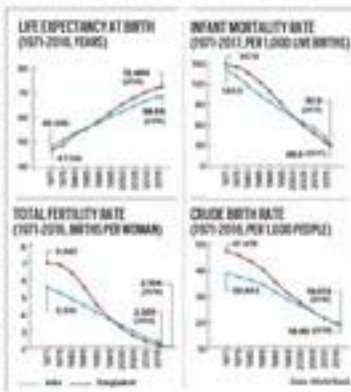
People are likely to produce fewer children when they are better educated, have more income, and have access to family planning. The country’s fertility rate has fallen from 6.5 in 1971 to 2.0 in 2018. In 2019, it was 1.9. In 2020, it was 1.8. In 2021, it was 1.7. In 2022, it was 1.6. In 2023, it was 1.5. In 2024, it was 1.4. In 2025, it was 1.3. In 2026, it was 1.2. In 2027, it was 1.1. In 2028, it was 1.0. In 2029, it was 0.9. In 2030, it was 0.8.

The country’s life expectancy at birth has also increased significantly. In 1971, it was 47. In 2018, it was 74. In 2019, it was 75. In 2020, it was 76. In 2021, it was 77. In 2022, it was 78. In 2023, it was 79. In 2024, it was 80. In 2025, it was 81. In 2026, it was 82. In 2027, it was 83. In 2028, it was 84. In 2029, it was 85. In 2030, it was 86.

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Hasina stood next to a mural depicting portraits of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina and other leaders in a public square in Dhaka, Bangladesh. She has made dramatic strides in improving the health of its women and children.



Major and other water that Bangladesh women were taught to make and administer to children suffering from diarrhoea. In 1971, it was 300. In 2018, it was 21. In 2019, it was 20. In 2020, it was 19. In 2021, it was 18. In 2022, it was 17. In 2023, it was 16. In 2024, it was 15. In 2025, it was 14. In 2026, it was 13. In 2027, it was 12. In 2028, it was 11. In 2029, it was 10. In 2030, it was 9.

Lessons from Bangladesh's development. The 2011 census in Bangladesh showed that the country's population was 150 million. The country's population growth rate was 1.4% in 2011. The country's life expectancy at birth was 74 in 2011. The country's infant mortality rate was 21 in 2011. The country's total fertility rate was 2.0 in 2011. The country's crude birth rate was 10 in 2011.

The country's population growth rate has also slowed significantly. In 1971, it was 2.4%. In 2018, it was 1.4%. In 2019, it was 1.3%. In 2020, it was 1.2%. In 2021, it was 1.1%. In 2022, it was 1.0%. In 2023, it was 0.9%. In 2024, it was 0.8%. In 2025, it was 0.7%. In 2026, it was 0.6%. In 2027, it was 0.5%. In 2028, it was 0.4%. In 2029, it was 0.3%. In 2030, it was 0.2%.

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

India and its neighborhood- relations.

IMPORTANT QUESTION

ESSAY/ MAINS / GD / INTERVIEWS

Bangladesh, which was much behind India half a century ago in various social indicators, is now relatively ahead in most of them. Examine the reasons for this transformation.

5 Lessons from Bangladesh elections

As PM Hasina storms back to power, her country stands on the cusp of transformative social and economic change — anticipated by interventions by state and society, already seen in development indicators.

The popular portrayal of Bangladesh in India is frequently unflattering — patronising at best and contemptuous at worst. Bangladeshis are “ghuspaithiye” — infiltrators and illegal immigrants — “termites” eating through India’s resources, and the alleged stealers of India’s cows and contributors to crime in the country.

More than anything else, what this discourse betrays is ignorance. For Bangladesh, once considered a basket case, is today a country that can impart to all its neighbours, India included, some excellent lessons in development. Consider: At the time of independence in 1971, Bangladesh was one of the world’s poorest countries — on par with Rwanda, Mali, Burundi, Somalia, Ethiopia and Upper Volta (as Burkina Faso was then called). With a population of 67 million, an estimated 71% of whom lived below the national poverty line, it produced barely 10 million tonnes (mt) of rice and was the second largest food-aid recipient after Egypt from 1975 to 1992.

The country’s poverty headcount ratio was 56.6% even in 1992, falling only gradually to 48.9% by 2000. But since then, this has declined dramatically to 24.3% in 2016. Also, while Bangladesh’s population has risen 2.5 times to 165 million since 1971, its rice production has soared 3.5 times to over 35 mt, enough to feed its people.

More impressive is the improvement in social indicators.

5 Lessons from Bangladesh elections

In 1971, Bangladesh's total fertility rate — the number of children women bear on an average during their lifetime — was 6.94. That rate had, by 2016, dropped to 2.1, below the 2.33 for India (which actually had a lower rate of 5.52 in 1971). Defying the so-called "Muslim" stereotype, the proportion of Bangladeshi women aged 15-49 years using contraceptives has increased from a mere 7.7% to 62.4% between 1976 and 2014. That figure for India was 53.5% in 2016, up from 35.3% in 1980, but indicating less impressive progress.

The success in population control has come alongside a massive fall in infant and under-five years mortality rates, from 147.9 and 221.4 per thousand live births respectively in 1971, to 26.9 and 32.4 in 2017. The same period also recorded a jump in the country's average life expectancy at birth — from 47.14 to 72.49 years (India: 68.56 years), and in the adult female literacy rate from under 10% to 70%-plus (India: 63%).

Parents are likely to produce fewer children when they are surer about their survival. Similarly, education makes women more aware of the need for family planning, apart from delaying the age of marriage.

The first is immunisation coverage, which for the four standard vaccines — BCG, DTP, oral polio and measles — was 1%-2% in Bangladesh until 1985. That coverage is now near 100%.

The second is open defecation, which Bangladesh practically eradicated by 2015. That was around the time India had launched the Swachh Bharat Mission, with roughly 40% of its population still practising what is a major source of waterborne diseases from cholera and dysentery to hepatitis.

The third is oral rehydration solution (ORS), a simple electrolyte blend of salt, sugar and clean water that Bangladeshi women were taught to make and administer to children suffering severe dehydration from diarrhoea. This homemade solution, later upscaled to pre-packed oral rehydration salts, proved much cheaper and more effective in rural areas than saline intravenous drips.

5 Lessons from Bangladesh elections

The results of these interventions are also manifested in nutrition indicators relating to prevalence of stunting (low height-for-age), wasting (low weight-for-height), and underweight (low weight-for-age) amongst children under 5. Between 1997 and 2017, these ratios for Bangladesh have dipped from 59.7%, 20.6% and 52.5% to 31%, 8%, and 22% respectively.

Behind these accomplishments are institutions that include not just the big NGOs such as Sir Fazle Hasan Abed's BRAC (which really pushed ORS on the ground), Social Marketing Company (which popularised contraception in Bangladesh), and Nobel Peace Laureate Prof Muhammad Yunus's Grameen Bank (which pioneered microfinance), but even the likes of LGED or Local Government Engineering Department. The LGED, under its first chief engineer Quamrul Islam Siddique (a Verghese Kurien or E Sreedharan-like figure), was instrumental in building and managing Bangladesh's rural roads network of some 360,000 km, one of the densest in the world. These, together with investments in rural electrification and shallow tubewell irrigation making it possible for farmers to grow an additional high-yielding winter season boro paddy crop, have contributed to Bangladesh becoming self-sufficient in rice.

The Bangladeshi development experience reveals two things about the country's policymaking.

First, clarity with regard to setting goals and a quiet pragmatism in meeting these. For the political leadership cutting across parties — Bangladesh's large-scale immunisation programme was, in fact, launched during the mid-eighties under the military dictatorship of H M Ershad — population control was an imperative for development. With it also came recognition of the need to focus on maternal and child health. Not only were even NGOs and social entrepreneurs like Fazle Hasan Abed made part of the exercise, a culture of independent evaluation of programmes too was established, expanding the ones that worked and scrapping those that didn't.

5 Lessons from Bangladesh elections

The same pragmatism, perhaps, explains Bangladesh going ahead with commercial cultivation of genetically modified Bt brinjal, a technology that India has rejected despite being developed by an Indian company.

The second is, of course, religion. The clerics could do nothing to stop family-planning efforts in Bangladesh, unlike in Pakistan, where the total fertility rate is still 3.5 and contraceptive prevalence among women of reproductive age is just 35.4%. The biggest lesson both India and Pakistan can learn from Bangladesh today is to keep religious fundamentalism at bay and not allow so-called defenders of faith to dictate policy. And that is probably what the Bangladeshi voter has shown yet again.

BANGLADESH ... ENORMOUS SOCIAL PROGRESS



POPULATION

1971	→	67 million
2018	→	165 million

BELOW POVERTY LINE

1971	→	71%
2016	→	24%

RICE PRODUCTION

1971	→	10 mill. ton
2018	→	35 mill. ton

TOTAL FERTILITY RATE

1971	→	6.94
2016	→	2.1

Second largest food-aid recipient after Egypt from 1975 to 1992

For India, it was 5.52 in 1971 and now 2.33

BANGLADESH ... ENORMOUS SOCIAL PROGRESS



WOMEN USING CONTRACEPTIVES

1976	→	7.7%
2014	→	62.4%

For India, it was 35% in 1980, now it is 54%

AVERAGE LIFE EXPECTANCY

1971	→	47
2017	→	72

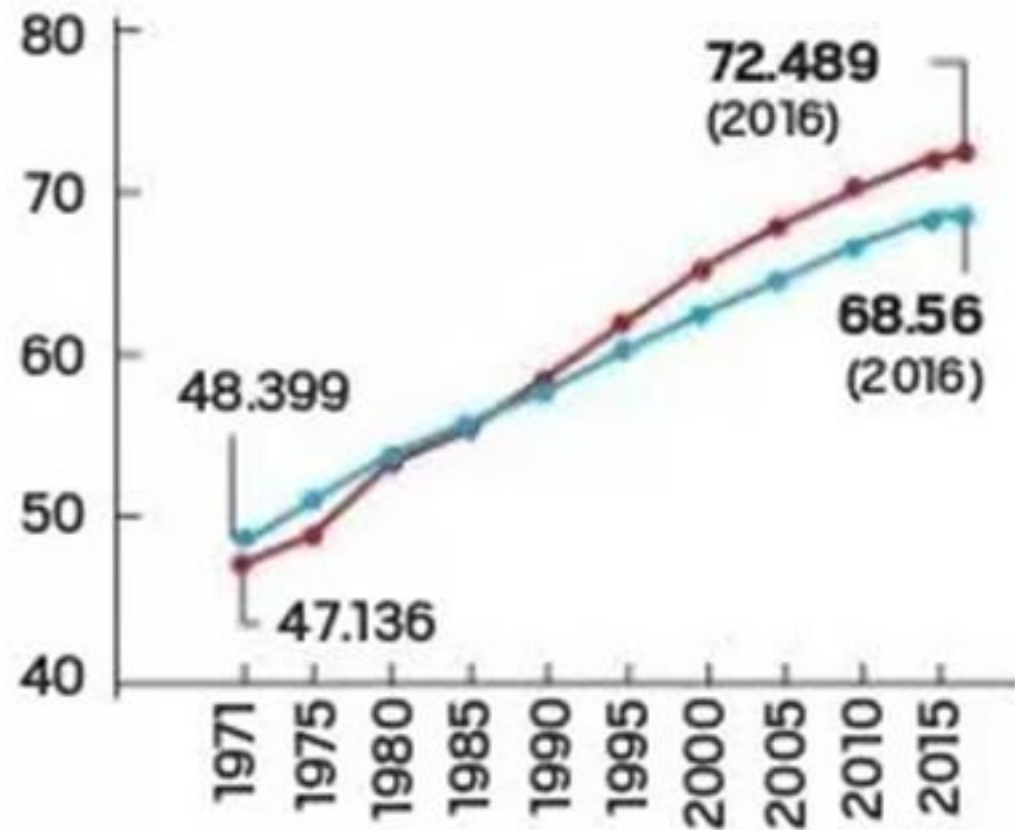
IMR

1971	→	148
2017	→	27

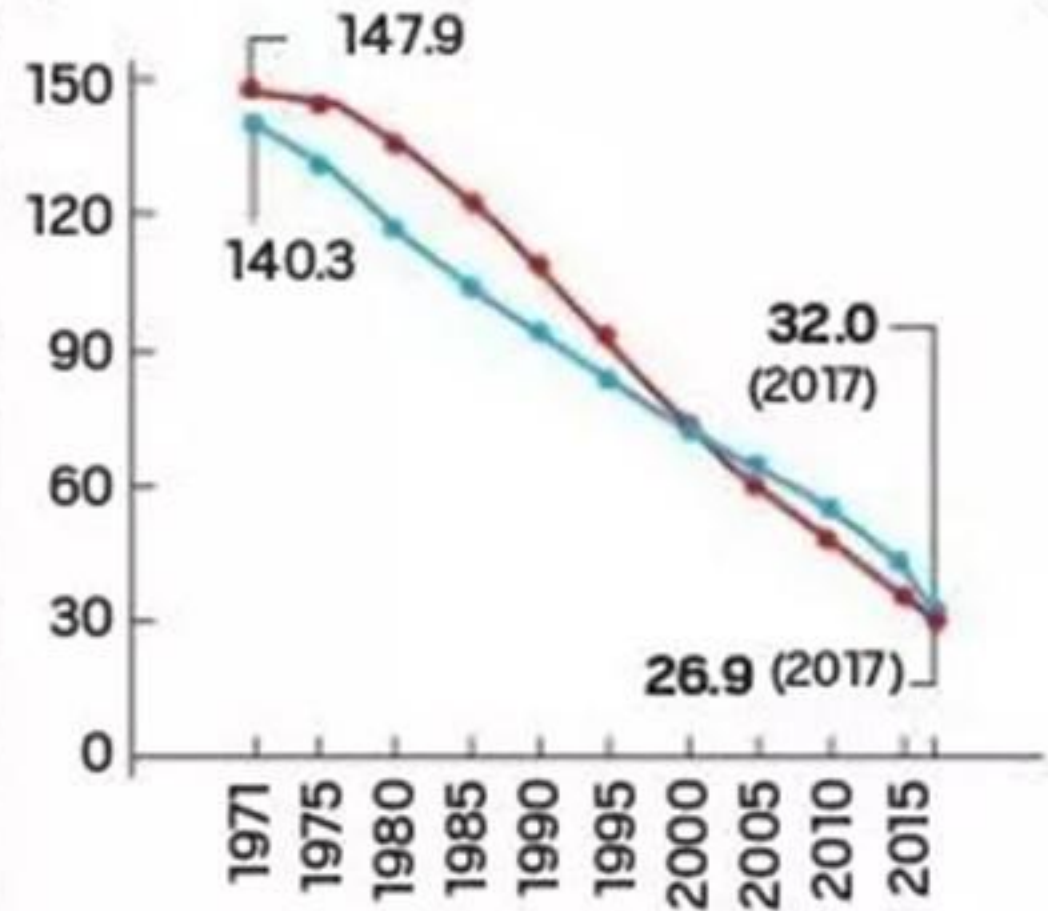
UNDER 5 MORTALITY

1971	→	221
2017	→	32

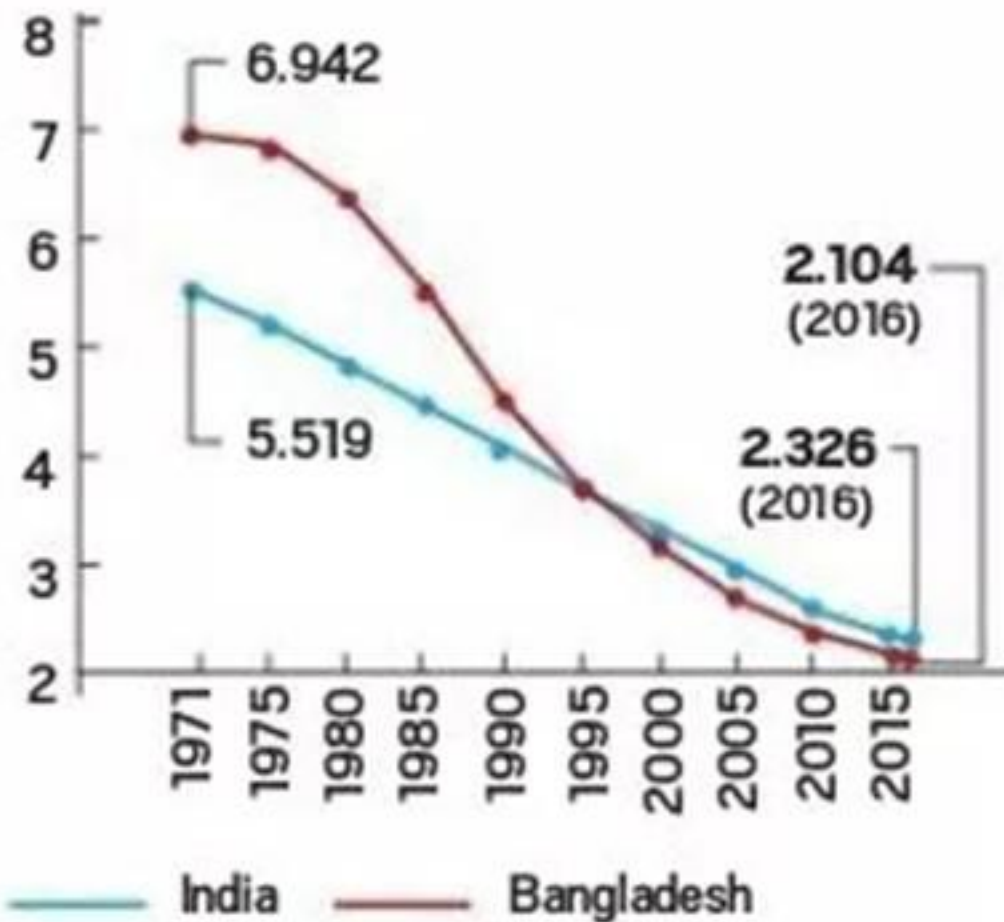
LIFE EXPECTANCY AT BIRTH (1971-2016, YEARS)



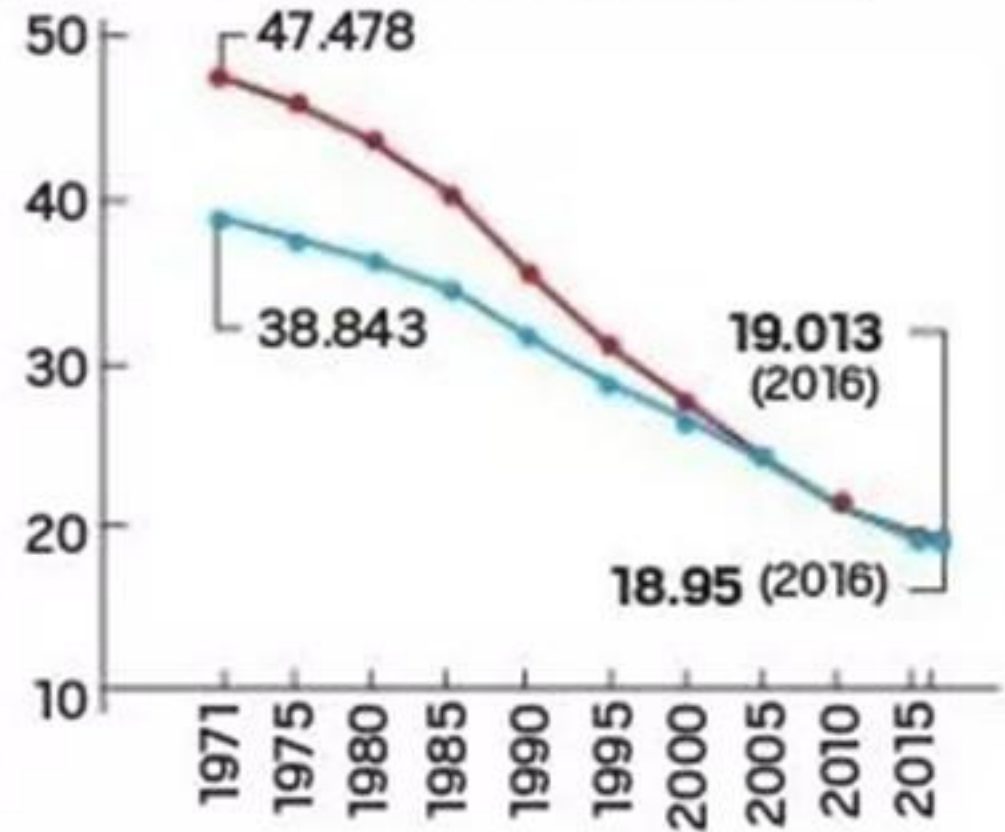
INFANT MORTALITY RATE (1971-2017, PER 1,000 LIVE BIRTHS)



TOTAL FERTILITY RATE (1971-2016, BIRTHS PER WOMAN)



CRUDE BIRTH RATE (1971-2016, PER 1,000 PEOPLE)



Data: World Bank

THREE SPECIFIC INTERVENTIONS WHICH REDUCED MORTALITY

1 IMMUNIZATION COVERAGE

For the four standard vaccines i.e., BCG, DTP, oral polio and measles, it was 1%-2% in Bangladesh until 1985 and the coverage is now nearly 100%.



2 OPEN DEFECATION

- Bangladesh practically eradicated open defecation by 2015.
- It is around the time India launched Swachh Bharat Mission.



3 ORAL REHYDRATION SOLUTION (ORS)

- It is a simple electrolyte blend of salt, sugar and clean water that Bangladeshi women were taught to make and administer to children suffering from severe dehydration from diarrhoea.
- The homemade solution, later upscaled to pre-packed oral rehydration salts. It proved much cheaper and more effective in rural areas than saline intravenous drips.

VOLUNTARY ORGANISATIONS ... PLAYED MUCH BIGGER ROLE

LIVE

1



Sir Fazle Hasan Abed's BRAC pushed Oral Rehydration Solution (ORS) on the ground.

2



Social Marketing Company popularised contraception in Bangladesh.

3



Nobel Peace Laureate Prof Muhammad Yunus' Grameen Bank pioneered microfinance.

4



LOCAL GOVERNMENT ENGINEERING DEPARTMENT
Local Government Division
Ministry of Local Government, Rural Development & Cooperatives

Local Government Engineering Department was instrumental in building and managing Bangladesh rural roads network of some 3,60,000 km, one of the densest in the World.

5



Investments in rural electrification.

6



Shallow tubewell irrigation making it possible for the farmers to grow an additional high-yielding winter season boro paddy crop.

TWO IMPORTANT ASPECTS

1 CLARITY IN SETTING THE GOALS

- 1 Clarity in setting the goals and pragmatism in meeting them is the important aspect.
- 2 Large scale immunisation programme was launched during the mid-eighties under the military dictatorship of H M Ershad.
- 3 The need for maternal and child health was also born at that time.
- 4 Culture of independent evaluation programs was established.
- 5 The same pragmatism explains how Bangladesh is going ahead with commercial cultivation of genetically modified Bt brinjal.

2 ROLE OF RELIGION

The clerics could do nothing to stop family-planning efforts in Bangladesh, unlike in Pakistan, where the Total Fertility Rate is still 3.5 and contraceptive prevalence among the women of reproductive age is just 35.4%.

The biggest lesson which can be learnt from Bangladesh is to keep religious fundamentalism at bay and not allow the defenders of faith to dictate policy.

WE EXPRESS OUR
SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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